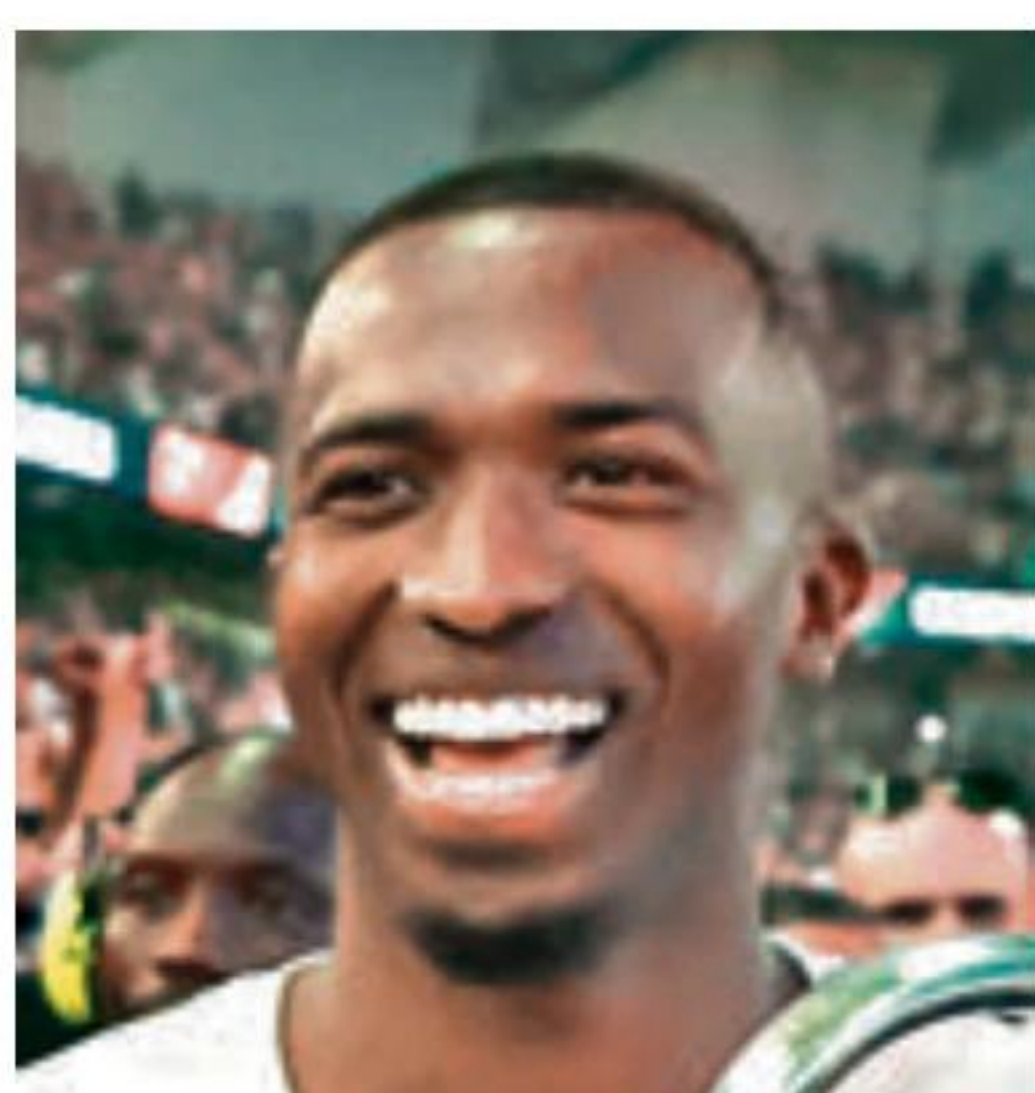


complemented by the experience of Moises Caicedo, provides the perfect triumvirate to stall counterattacks from the opponents.

And if Ecuador's pragmatism becomes too predictable, add the seasoning of attacks by teenage sensation Kendry Paez and seasoned runs of Enner Valencia to complete a well-balanced squad. It was thus not too surprising to see the side finish second in the World Cup qualifiers, just behind Argentina, and losing only to the defending world champion and Brazil in the entire qualification campaign.

Its first World Cup opponent this time — Ivory Coast — can also throw in a spanner, bringing Europe-tested stars to the quadrennial showpiece. From former AC Milan midfielder Frank Kessie to Manchester United's fleet-footed winger Amad Diallo, the Elephants can mount a surprise with their quick counters — as they did at the victorious 2023 African Cup of Nations — while Europa League-winning defender Evan Ndicka can exploit his aerial advantage through set pieces.

Their coach, Emerson Fae, inspired the side back into the World Cup after 12 years, and naturally, he will not let his wards go down without a fight.



Willian Pacho
(Ecuador)

Alex Ferguson once said, 'Attack wins you games, defence wins you titles.' It is no surprise that when Paris Saint-Germain won consecutive Champions League titles, Pacho was one of the key players at the back. The World Cup has seldom, like in 2006, elevated defenders to the status of heroes, and Pacho puts a strong case forward for Ecuador in that aspect.



Amad Diallo
(Ivory Coast)

The 23-year-old Ivorian's biggest talent has been finding spaces in tiny pockets in the final third. As a result, he has scored just twice for his club but assisted four more, helping Manchester United finish third in the Premier League. Diallo, along with Evann Guessand on the wings, can be a potent attack, with the latter coming in after winning both the Europa League and Conference League.

SQUADS

Germany

Goalkeepers: Manuel Neuer, Oliver Baumann, Alexander Nübel

Defenders: Antonio Rüdiger, Jonathan Tah, Nico Schlotterbeck, Waldemar Anton, David Raum, Malick Thiaw, Nathaniel Brown, Joshua Kimmich

Midfielders: Florian Wirtz, Jamal Musiala, Leon Goretzka, Angelo Stiller, Lennart Karl, Nadiem Amiri, Aleksandar Pavlović, Felix Nmecha, Pascal Gross

Forwards: Kai Havertz, Deniz Undav, Leroy Sané, Jamie Leweling, Nick Woltemade, Maximilian Beier

Curacao

Goalkeepers: Tyrick Bodak, Trevor Doornbusch, Eloy Room

Defenders: Riechedly Bazoer, Joshua Brenet, Roshon Van Eijma, Sherel Floranus, Deveron Fonville, Juriën Gaari, Armando Obispo, Shurandy Sambo

Midfielders: Juninho Bacuna, Leandro Bacuna, Livano Comenencia, Kevin Felida, Ar'jany Martha, Tyrese Noslin, Godfried Roemeratoe

Forwards: Jeremy Antonisse, Tahith Chong, Kenji Gorré, Sontje Hansen, Gervane Kastaneer, Brandley Kuwas, Jürgen Locadia, Jearl Margaritha

Ecuador

Goalkeepers: Hernan Galindez, Moises Ramirez, Gonzalo Valle

Defenders: Piero Hincapie, Willian Pacho, Pervis Estupinan, Felix Torres, Joel Ordonez, Jackson Porozo, Angelo Preciado

Midfielders: Moises Caicedo, Alan Franco, Kendry Paez, Pedro Vite, Jordy Alcivar, Denil Castillo, Yaimar Medina

Forwards: Enner Valencia, Gonzalo Plata, Alan Minda, John Yeboah, Kevin Rodriguez, Jordy Caicedo, Nilson Angulo, Anthony Valencia, Jeremy Arevalo

Ivory Coast

Goalkeepers: Yahia Fofana, Mohamed Koné, Alban Lafont

Defenders: Emmanuel Agbadou, Christopher Operi, Ousmane Diomandé, Guéla Doué, Ghislain Konan, Odilon Kossounou, Evan Ndicka, Wilfried Singo

Midfielders: Seko Fofana, Parfait Guiagon, Christ Inao Oulaï, Franck Kessié, Ibrahim Sangaré, Jean-Mickaël Seri

Forwards: Simon Adingra, Ange-Yoan Bonny, Amad Diallo, Oumar Diakité, Yan Diomandé, Evann Guessand, Nicolas Pépé, Bazoumana Touré, Elye Wahi